Leonardo AI Prompting

What it is: Leonardo AI is an AI art platform that offers both image and some video generation. It's powered by diffusion models (like Stable Diffusion under the hood) but provides a **user-friendly interface and a library of specialized models** (e.g. Leonardo's own fine-tuned models for certain styles). It also has features like **prompt weight sliders, negative prompt fields, ControlNet**, etc., without needing technical setup. For our purposes, Leonardo can be seen as a more guided way to use Stable Diffusion techniques.

How to use it: In Leonardo's interface, you type a prompt similar to SD or MJ, select a model (such as their **Leonardo Signature** for general art, **Anime XL** for anime style, etc.), choose aspect ratio or resolution, and generate. You can adjust advanced settings (number of images, guidance, etc.) or just use defaults.

- **Prompting:** The same principles of clarity and style from SD prompting apply. Because Leonardo tends to **follow prompts quite literally** (it's noted for taking instructions more literally, which is great for precise needs), make sure your prompt is clean and focused. For example: *"**Cinematic close-up** of a **chef plating a gourmet dish** in a high-end restaurant kitchen – shallow depth of field, rich warm lighting, extremely detailed, 4K."* If using the **Leonardo Select** or **Leonardo Signature** model, you'd get a realistic image with those characteristics. If you switch to an illustrative model, the style would change accordingly, without changing the prompt.

- **Parameters in Leonardo:** You'll find typical settings like **guidance scale** (how strongly it follows the prompt), **step count** (more steps can yield finer detail but slower), and obviously **aspect ratio selection**. They often provide presets for vertical, square, etc. Choose a vertical preset or input resolution for TikTok dimensions (1080x1920, etc.). Leonardo also offers **negative prompt box** – use it to remove things you don't want, just like in SD.

- **Unique features:** One standout is Leonardo's **"ControlNet Suite"** which allows things like pose conditioning or sketch guiding easily through the UI. If you want a specific composition (say you want your subject in a certain part of the frame), you can upload a rough sketch or pose reference and the AI will follow that layout. This is incredibly useful for ensuring your AI-generated image has space for overlay text or fits a TikTok overlay format. Leonardo also has **tiling**, **upscaling**, and other utilities built in, which can come handy for production polish.

- **AI Video in Leonardo:** Leonardo AI includes an **AI Video Generator** feature. This isn't as prominent as Runway or Sora, but it's there. It can generate short looping animations or video clips from prompts or from image sequences. If you're on Leonardo, it's worth exploring to create quick motion loops (for example, a swirling background or an object rotating). However, for more complex video, dedicated tools like Sora or Runway might be preferable.

- **Example prompt (Leonardo, using a specific model):**
  *"[Leonardo Anime XL] **Epic anime-style scene**: a superheroine on a skyscraper roof at sunset, cape flowing in wind. Dynamic angle from below. **Vibrant colors**, action-packed, particles in the air, anime lighting flare."*
  In Leonardo, you'd select the **Leonardo Anime XL** model (tailored for anime look) and input the above prompt. The result would likely be a fantastic vertical anime illustration suitable for an animation keyframe or thumbnail. If you use a different model like **Leonardo Realistic**, the same prompt (minus the anime references) would yield a photographic style. The ability to switch models is like changing "lenses" – it gives flexibility.

- **Tip:** Leonardo has daily generation limits (for free tier) but it's quite generous with features. Use the community feed for inspiration – often you can find prompts other users ran and even one-click use them. Studying those prompts can improve your own skills.

Common Prompt Elements for All Image Tools: No matter which platform, some prompt ingredients are universally helpful for visual consistency and appeal:

- **Aspect Ratio:** Always consider it. For vertical video content, mention it or set it (9:16). Midjourney uses `--ar`, Stable Diffusion/Leonardo can use resolution values. Getting the aspect right means your image fills the frame without awkward cropping.

- **References and Style**: Don't shy away from naming a style or artist if permissible. "In the style of Studio Ghibli" or "90s cartoon style" instantly conveys a lot to the AI. Or for photography: "cinematic, like a still from a Scorsese film" can influence composition and lighting.

- **Visual Identity:** If you want a series of assets to have a cohesive look (say you're making 5 videos that should feel branded), reuse certain prompt phrases across all generations. For example, always include "golden warm lighting and teal shadows" in each prompt to get a similar color grade, or use the same model/preset each time. This helps build a consistent visual identity.

- **Quality and Detail:** Words like *"highly detailed, ultra HD, 8K"* can push for detail. But note, some tools (Midjourney, DALL·E 3) might not need these as much – they default to high quality. Overusing "8K, UHD, award-winning photo" in every prompt can sometimes lead to weirdly similar looks. Use them when you truly need more detail or realism.

- **Examples & Inspiration Images:** If the tool allows image prompting (all mentioned do, in some form), use it! For instance, if you love the color scheme of a particular painting, you could feed that image with a prompt "use similar color palette." This often guides the AI better than words can.

By mastering these prompt techniques, you can quickly generate storyboards, character images, or even short clips for your TikToks and Reels. The AI can handle the heavy lifting of creation; your job is to **communicate your vision through the prompt**. As the saying goes: *"The devil is in the [prompt] details!"* And remember – always check the usage rights and community guidelines of each platform when using AI-generated media, especially for commercial content.